“I have to be useful to be wanted.”

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Where it often comes from

Some of us learned that we were welcome when we helped: when we cooked, listened, fixed, drove, or gave. If affection came mostly when we were useful, we learned that our value was our usefulness. As adults, we may say yes to everything, feel panic at being a guest, and quietly wonder whether anyone would want us around without what we provide.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” John says, “Love consists in this: not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son as the atoning sacrifice for our sins.” The LORD “will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love.” Accepted by Christ, we are told, “Accept one another, then, just as Christ accepted you.” God wants you, not just what you do. Serving others is a good thing, but it is not the price of belonging.

> *“And love consists in this: not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son as the atoning sacrifice for our sins”* (1 John 4:10).

Also see

> “But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” (Romans 5:8).

> “The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing” (Zephaniah 3:17).

> “Accept one another, then, just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring glory to God” (Romans 15:7).

> “I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well” (Psalm 139:14).

Common self-statements

- If I stop helping, they will drop me.
- I must earn my place.
- I am only wanted when I am needed.
- I cannot just be a guest.
- My value is in what I give.
- If I say no, I will be left out.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting rejection if I stop being useful.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either useful and wanted or useless and unwanted.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must always contribute.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling anxious when not helping and concluding I am unwanted.

Challenging questions

- When did I learn that I am wanted for what I do?

- Has anyone enjoyed my company when I was not doing anything useful?
- What would happen if I said no to one request?
- How does God want me?
- What would it be like to receive without giving back?
- Who could I simply enjoy time with?

Truth summary

> I am wanted for who I am, not only for what I provide. God's love was given before I did anything, and I can be with others without earning my place. I can serve out of love, not out of fear of being dropped.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Love, By God
- Servant
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Friendship
- Grace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Weak/Tired

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have to be useful to be wanted"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to be useful to be wanted." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did I learn I am wanted for usefulness?
- ☐ Who enjoys me for myself?
- ☐ What would a no cost me?
- ☐ How does God want me?
- ☐ Can I receive without repaying?
- ☐ Who can I just be with?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God loved me first.
- ☐ I am wanted for who I am.
- ☐ Service is a gift, not a fee.
- ☐ I can receive as well as give.
- ☐ Rest does not cost me love.
- ☐ I can enjoy people without being useful.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 John 4:10
  "And love consists in this: not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son as the atoning sacrifice for our sins."
- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."
- ☐ Zephaniah 3:17
  "The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Just being: Each week, spend time with someone without doing anything for them and note how it felt.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 John 4:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God loved me first, so I do not have to earn my place.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Love, By God" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Notice the pattern. Write when you say yes out of fear.
- [ ] Practice one no. Decline a small request kindly and see what happens.
- [ ] Receive a gift. Accept help or a compliment without repaying it.
- [ ] Read Zephaniah 3:17. Let it settle that God delights in you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to be useful to be wanted": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A time of just being
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to be useful to be wanted.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have tried to earn my place. Thank You that You love me first. Teach me to rest in being wanted and to serve out of love, not fear. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.